I THINK THERE ARE PLACES WHERE THE CONGRESS WILL WIN. WHETHER IT WILL BE ENOUGH TO FORM A GOVERNMENT, I CANNOT SAY. BUT LET'S ASSUME PM MODI'S PARTY, THE BJP, GETS THE MAJORITY AND FORMS THE GOVERNMENT. SO WE WILL BE IN THE OPPOSITION. OPPOSITION ALSO MATTERS IN A DEMOCRACY, DOESN'T IT?

The day electoral bonds were introduced, I said it was legalised bribery

▶ **P. CHIDAMBARAM,**
Former Union Minister of Finance and Home Affairs

CHALLENGING INEVITABILITY

Articulate and combative, lawyer-politician P. Chidambaram asserted that nothing was inevitable in politics despite pundits pointing out that the Narendra Modi-led National Democratic Alliance was poised to win a third term in a row. While the Congress manifesto committee chairman said his party would do better this time, he admitted he couldn't say whether it would form the next government.

Why so? The Hindi-speaking north Indian states seem to be swayed by the Ram temple fervour, he said. When there is massive unemployment, significant poverty and huge gaps in education and healthcare, and still people are not voting against an incumbent government, it must be for some other reason. The reason, he explained, is the Hindutva wave. So, people who are voting for Hindutva will vote for Modi. But, he cautioned, the problems facing the country will remain unaddressed and people will suffer.

Claiming that electoral bonds were legalised bribery, Chidambaram advocated a multi-pronged approach in funding elections. Bringing it back overground, considering that the Election Commission's restrictions have driven campaigning underground, is the first priority. His other recommendations are: Raise the limit for election expenses; introduce state funding on a politically neutral formula; and revert to transparent donations to political parties. ■



KEY TAKEAWAYS

- If people don't vote against the incumbent government..., it is because of the Hindutva wave sweeping Hindi-speaking northern states. So, if people are voting for Hindutva, they will naturally vote for Modi
- The Congress can win more than the 2019 Lok Sabha polls in Telangana, Karnataka and Haryana. In Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, the I.N.D.I.A. bloc expects to repeat its 2019 performance when it won 39 of 40 seats
- The Modi government has weaponised the Prevention of Money Laundering Act and uses it to tame or destroy its political opponents